

Bettongia penicillata

Brush-tailed bettong



Length 12–15 in (30–38 cm)
Tail 11½–14 in (29–36 cm)
Weight 1¼–3¼ lb (0.8–1.8 kg)

Location S.W. Australia
Social unit Individual
Status Critically endangered



Like the potoroo family (see p.99), the brush-tailed bettong—also called the woylie—is a fungivore. It forages in woodland soil by night, scraping earth to find the fungi, which form 90 percent of its diet. The remainder of its diet comprises roots, bulbs, tubers, and worms. This bettong has a tail almost as long as its head and body, with a crest of black fur along the upper side. By day, it shelters in a large, domed nest of bark, leaves, and grass.



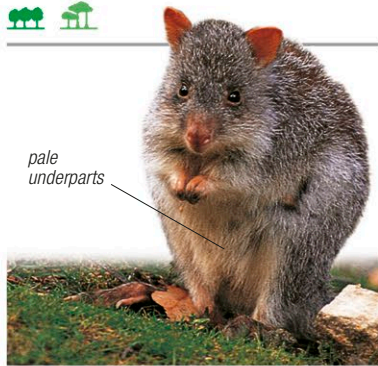
Aepyrymnus rufescens

Rufous bettong



Length 13½–19 in (34–48 cm)
Tail 12–16 in (31–41 cm)
Weight ¾–6½ lb (1.3–3 kg)

Location E. Australia
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern



Grizzled red-brown fur over the body gives this rat-kangaroo its name of rufous bettong, although some fur is white. It uses its grasping tail to gather grasses and stems for its tall, cone-shaped nest, which it builds on the woodland floor, often against a log or tree; one individual may have 5 such refuges. The diet is fungi, grass, roots, leaves, flowers, seeds, and small invertebrates. The single young leaves the pouch after 16 weeks.

Lagorchestes conspicillatus

Spectacled hare wallaby



Length 16–19 in (40–48 cm)
Tail 14½–20 in (37–50 cm)
Weight ¾–10 lb (1.5–4.5 kg)

Location N. Australia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



A conspicuous orange eye patch in the generally shaggy, white-grizzled, gray-brown coat gives this small

member of the kangaroo family the name of spectacled hare wallaby. It grazes by night, usually alone, on grasses and herbs, and hides in a burrow or thicket by day. After 29–31 days' gestation, the single young stays in the pouch for 5 months, and is weaned by 7 months.



Setonix brachyurus

Quokka



Length 16–21½ in (40–54 cm)
Tail 10–14 in (25–35 cm)
Weight ¾–10 lb (1.5–4.5 kg)

Location S.W. Australia (Rottnest and Bald islands)
Social unit Group
Status Vulnerable



Very rare on mainland Australia, the quokka survives on 2 islands off the southwest coast, mainly because introduced predators such as foxes are absent. This small wallaby frequents thick forest, open woodland, low scrub, and swamp edges or river banks where available. After resting by day in

dense vegetation, it feeds at night on leaves, grasses, and fruit. Small family groups associate as larger gatherings, which maintain a group territory. Gestation is 27 days; the single young leaves the pouch after 6 months.

CONSERVATION

Between 5,000 and 15,000 quokkas live on Rottnest Island. As well as being a popular tourist attraction, they have enabled scientists to carry out detailed research into marsupial biology—essential knowledge for their future conservation.



COMPACT SHAPE

The quokka has a rounded body, short ears and snout, and a stout tail. Its dense, coarse fur is brown, tinged red around the face and neck.



Thylogale stigmatica

Red-legged pademelon



Length 15–23 in (38–58 cm)
Tail 12–18½ in (30–47 cm)
Weight 5½–15 lb (2.5–7 kg)

Location N. and E. Australia, New Guinea
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This slender-headed, stout-bodied, thick-tailed pademelon (a type of small wallaby) tends to be brown-gray in rain forests but paler fawn in open woodland. Active both day and night, it is usually solitary but may gather in groups at a fruiting tree to feed. Other foods include leaves and seeds.



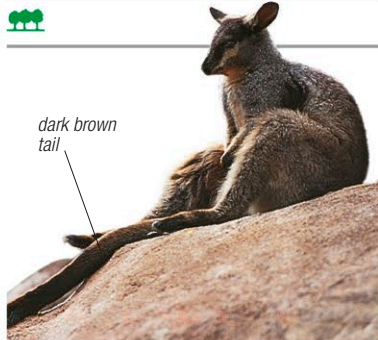
Petrogale penicillata

Brush-tailed rock wallaby



Length 20–23½ in (50–60 cm)
Tail 20–28 in (50–70 cm)
Weight 8½–24 lb (4–11 kg)

Location S.E. Australia
Social unit Group
Status Near threatened



The rock wallaby is specialized for leaping and scrambling over boulders, cliffs, ledges, and outcrops. It can make single bounds of 13 ft (4 m), and the soles of the rear feet are enlarged, padded, and roughened, providing excellent grip. By day, this wallaby rests in a cool rock crevice or cave, occasionally sunbathing. At night, it feeds on grasses, ferns, bush leaves, and fruit. Colonies may exceed 70 in number.

Petrogale concinna

Little rock wallaby



Length 11½–14 in (29–35 cm)
Tail 9–12 in (22–31 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 kg)

Location N. Australia
Social unit Individual
Status Data deficient



Similar to the brush-tailed rock wallaby (see left) in form and habits, this species—also called the nabarlek—has short, silky, reddish brown fur with a dark shoulder stripe and brush-tipped tail. It grazes alone by night on grass and sedge, but its main food in the dry season is nardoo (a tough fern). To cope with this abrasive food, the wallaby's molar teeth slowly move forward in the jaw as they wear, and are then replaced by another set—a process of repeated tooth replacement unique among marsupials.